

Veterans Guide

What the VA provides, what the veterans sections give you, and what a family still pays.

The space is our gift

Both veterans sections give the **burial space at no charge** to a qualifying veteran, and the gift follows you: if your family is resting elsewhere in the park, we apply the same credit toward a space beside them. What remains are the charges tied to the interment itself.

What the VA provides

Choosing a private cemetery forfeits none of it. **None of it is automatic** either: every one has to be applied for with proof of service, and we prepare and submit those for you.

Headstone or marker

Furnished at no charge for an unmarked grave, in any cemetery. In a private cemetery the base and the setting are the family's expense.

Burial flag

To drape the casket or accompany the urn, presented to the next of kin. We request it for you.

Military funeral honors

The folding and presentation of the flag and the sounding of Taps. Rendered here, and the family does not pay for them.

Presidential Memorial Certificate

Signed by the President. You may request more than one, so each child can have their own.

Start with the DD-214

The discharge certificate is what the VA relies on to confirm eligibility. Without it a marker cannot be ordered and honors cannot be scheduled. Hand me a copy now and I will keep it on file with your arrangement.

Tahoma, or here

Tahoma National Cemetery in Kent costs nothing, and for some families it is the right answer. Three things separate it from our veterans sections. **You cannot choose or reserve a grave there**; it is assigned at the time of need. **Tahoma takes a spouse and dependent children**, where the veterans sections take three generations and first responders. **Tahoma schedules around its own calendar**, which often means a wait. Whichever you choose, the funeral home half is the same, the VA covers none of it, and we arrange both halves at one table.

The Veterans Sections

Washington Memorial Park has two sections set aside for those who served in the armed forces and in public safety: **the Veterans Garden** and **Veterans North**. The burial space in either one is given at no charge to a qualifying veteran.

The gift follows the veteran, not the section

If your family is already resting in another part of Washington Memorial Park, you do not have to choose between the veterans sections and being with them. We apply the same veteran's property gift toward a space in that section instead, so a veteran can be laid to rest beside a spouse, a parent, or a child rather than apart from them.

The gift is a flat credit toward the space you choose. If that section is priced higher than the veterans sections, you pay the difference. Niches work a little differently, so ask me.

Endowment care fund

A permanent fund whose earnings maintain the grounds, required by the state. It is figured on what the property is worth, so it is owed in full even on a space we give at no charge

Opening and closing

Preparing the grave before the service and closing it afterward

Recording fee

Entering the interment in the permanent cemetery record

Burial vault

The outer container that surrounds and protects the casket

Vault setting

Placing the vault in the grave

Washington sales tax

Applies to merchandise and its installation. Interment and recording services are exempt

Who may be laid to rest here. Veterans discharged under any condition other than dishonorable. Three generations of family: a spouse even if they remarry, children and grandchildren and their spouses. And first responders, whom a national cemetery does not take: law enforcement, career and volunteer firefighters, EMTs and paramedics, 911 dispatchers, and correctional officers.

Three things to plan around

Two caskets cannot share a space, but a casket and an urn can. The gift covers the veteran; a spouse or family member who did not serve is charged half the cost of the plot as a second right of interment, with endowment care on that right as well.

The order matters. Arranging the space together ahead of time protects that half-cost pricing whoever is laid to rest first. Without it, a spouse laid to rest before the veteran can be charged the full cost. None of us choose that order, which is why it is worth settling now.

Adjacent spaces are not guaranteed later. Families who want to be side by side should choose their spaces at the same time.

Choosing a marker

The government marker is free. Placing it is not. In a private cemetery the granite base it sits on, and the setting, are the family's expense, so the real choice is between two prices and they are closer together than most families expect. Granite is priced all-inclusive of the stone, engraving, setting and tax, and it is the only material that offers stone colours, custom scenes, photo portraits and diamond etching. At Tahoma the headstone is furnished *and* set at no cost. Ask me for the Granite Marker Guide and I will price the two side by side.

TWO THINGS FAMILIES ASK

Can my spouse be buried beside me?

Yes, and so can your children, their spouses, your grandchildren, and their spouses.

What if we cannot find the DD-214?

A replacement can be requested from the National Archives at no cost, and more recent records are often available through milConnect. It takes time, so it is far better to do it now than at need. We are glad to walk you through the request.

Bring your DD-214 and your questions

There is no cost to talk it through and no obligation. We will walk both veterans sections, go through the cemetery and the funeral home side together, and I will put real numbers in writing for you. Take as long as you need afterward.

Martice Morrison · (206) 445-9794 · mmorrison@bonneywatson.com